



Buying Tips for Laptops

- **Battery Usage:** Before purchasing a portable laptop check the battery life. Be cautious as many manufacturers will indicate a battery usage time at the lowest possible power settings.
- **Modem and Network Card:** If you use a dial-up Internet connection, ensure that a modem is included with the portable laptop. In addition, verify if the modem is an internal or PC-CARD (PCMCIA) modem, as you may require all the available PC-CARD slots in the future. PC-CARD modems are Type II; Network PC-CARDS are also Type II: if the laptop needs to be connected to a LAN, you need to ensure that it has a network card. Again, verify whether the card is integrated or PCMCIA.
- **Documentation:** Although most manufacturers today tend to reduce the amount of documentation included with laptops, all laptop manufacturers will include some type of paper documentation or paper inserts. But check if this includes documentation on upgrading the laptop in the future, about connecting the required cables and how to use the bundled software.
- **Refurbished Laptops:** 'Refurbished' is a term used to describe a laptop or a hardware device, that contains one or more component that's been used or repaired. Refurbished laptops will have a lower price and are generally a good deal for the budget-conscious.
- **Software:** Does the software include Microsoft Office or Corel Suite? These packages allow you to have a word processor and/or a spreadsheet. For the

majority of all users this should be an important consideration. Are the software full-version or just demo programs and shareware?

■ **Legal software:** When purchasing a laptop, make sure it comes with legal software. Many end-users or small laptop companies who build or sell laptops may not provide you with legal copies of the software. Verify that the software that came with your laptop is on an original CD and has a software licence or registration number. An example of software that includes such certificates and/or licenses is Microsoft.

■ **Beware of Scams:** It's possible to overclock a processor, making it appear to be faster than it's rated for. To determine the processor speed, open the laptop and look at the processor itself. Do not look at the processor through a software program or through BIOS, as these values can be changed.

■ **Upgradability:** You may not consider this at first when purchasing a laptop, but it is important all the same. Here are some options to look for when upgrading the laptop: RAM, CPU, Hard Drive, etc. Are the upgrades something that you can do yourself, or does it require a visit to a service centre?

■ **Location:** Before you buy a laptop, make sure you can easily return it to the dealer if it proves unsatisfactory. Also check if the dealer can service your laptop. If not, where is the closest location where your laptop can be serviced?

Buying Tips for Handheld Devices

- **Memory:** Depending on the types of applications you plan to use, a handheld's integrated memory could run out faster than you'd imagine. You will need at least 4 MB of memory for text-based applications, and 16 MB for storing media files.
- **Compatibility:** Your handheld should support your applications. It should also be able to communicate with your desktop PC and preferably with other handheld devices.
- **Expandability and upgradability:** Choose handhelds that allow the OS to be upgraded to higher versions. Also, look out for ones that allow the firmware to be upgraded through flashing.
- **Screen size and resolution:** Monochrome screens are suitable for most applications; colour screens are for those who intend to work with graphics and video files. Look for a colour screen with good resolution, clarity and brightness, and one that is clearly legible in darkness as well as in bright light.
- **Battery life:** Make sure it has a run time of at least 10 hours, or you'll find yourself spending a lot of money on batteries.
- **Integrated features:** Opt for devices with additional features such as a cellular phone or camera only if you are going to actually use them. These frills add significantly to the cost.

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